

Fran Bow: Adapting Nonsense Literature Into Point-and-Click Adventure Games

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The point-and-click adventure genre has long been the subject of criticism for its propensity towards confusing and, oftentimes, convoluted gameplay. The issue lies in that by pointing and clicking on characters and objects, the player is encouraged to freely investigate their environment and experiment with items, but is nonetheless restricted to a single path of forward progress preordained by the game designer. Should the designer's intent not be readily apparent or otherwise not align with the logical thought process of the player, the player may decide to brute force a path forward by attempting every interaction they can conceive of. If the player exhausts all options and still fails to find a path towards progress, they are left stumped and unsure of how to proceed. Coupled with the genre's historical usage of esoteric puzzles and unintuitive leaps in logic, it is no surprise that the genre is commonly regarded as confusing. The 2015 point-and-click adventure *Fran Bow* is no exception. However, *Fran Bow* turns this potential weakness of the genre into one of its greatest strengths. In contrast to games of its kind, the story of *Fran Bow* pulls inspiration from literary nonsense, a genre that is characterized by the subversion of logic and reason. By choosing to tell a story that is deliberately confusing and illogical, the gameplay ends up in service to the narrative, complementing it instead of detracting from it. *Fran Bow* uses the conventional confusion-inducing gameplay structure of a point-and-click adventure game to effectively tell a nonsense narrative, convincingly portraying the disoriented and fractured mental state of a traumatized, or otherwise mentally unwell, individual in desperate need of kindness.

The story follows the titular protagonist Fran Bow, a mentally unwell young girl, after the gruesome and tragic murder of her parents. Thereafter admitted to a mental asylum, Fran makes

a daring escape and embarks on a journey back home to her Aunt Grace. Accompanied by her pet black cat, Mr. Midnight, Fran encounters a slew of whimsical, but equally horrific, supernatural events and entities of ambiguous veritableness.

As a point-and-click adventure game, *Fran Bow* possesses many of the genre's defining features and mechanics. The main emphasis is placed on dialogue, narration, puzzle solving, and pointing as means of progress. By clicking on desired objects and locations, the player can make Fran move throughout and in-between rooms, as well as interact with and inspect the environment, characters, and items (Vranešević 2014).

However, *Fran Bow*, as well as all other point-and-click adventures, possesses an incongruity that is at the core of its structure. The incongruity is that “[point-and-click] adventure games are on the one hand based on the assumption that all the in-game possibilities are prearranged, so that the player is only left to acknowledge and approve the already adopted path. But on the other hand, the genre [thrives] on experimenting with the game mechanism, where the contingent acts of pointing retroactively undermined the necessity of such preconditioned actions” (Vranešević 2014). In other words, the genre encourages the player to freely investigate the game environment and experiment with items, but this freedom is simultaneously undermined by the reality that all interactions and paths towards progress are preordained and often very specific or limited.

This can have varying adverse results. If the game lacks sufficient gameplay elements that make the player feel that their actions are having a significant impact on the narrative, then they may feel like a mere observer of events on the screen. On the opposite end, if the game overemphasizes non-narrative elements, the player may feel that a thoughtful story is being repeatedly interrupted by impossible puzzles (Vranešević 2014). In either case, this incongruity

often causes confusion and even frustration. When the player clicks on an object or character in an attempt to interact with it, their thought process may not necessarily align with the intent of the game designer. Usually, such attempts will not result in an interaction of consequence or any interaction at all. The player may soon find themselves performing tedious brute-force methods, attempting all interactions they can conceive of until one works or until they have exhausted their ideas, and “before [the] tale is through [the player will] have pointed and clicked on every man, woman, beast, and object in sight” (Vranešević 2014). If no significant progress is made by the end, the player will only be left wondering what the game actually expects from them, only able to guess at a solution, instead of engaging logically with the puzzles.

Fran Bow is no exception to this idiosyncrasy, but the game takes what is arguably a weakness of the genre and turns it into one of its greatest strengths. The narrative of *Fran Bow* is deliberately confusing and illogical, told from the perspective of Fran, who is not only exceptionally imaginative, but also very mentally unwell and high on drugs. Fran is, without a doubt, an unreliable narrator, and the player has no way of ascertaining which events in-game are objectively real and which are fabrications of Fran’s mind. In telling this style of story, the cryptic nature of a point-and-click adventure complements the overall intended experience of the game instead of detracting from it.

However, *Fran Bow* is not the only game of its kind to feature a confusing and cryptic narrative. In fact, point-and-click adventures have a long history as mystery games. To understand why *Fran Bow* excels then, it is important to understand some common features found in narratives of this genre and identify how *Fran Bow* differs from these titles. As it turns out, *Fran Bow* is set apart from other titles by one subtle difference.

The origin of the genre provides insight into this matter. The point-and-click adventure genre, including *Fran Bow*, falls under the umbrella of the genre of graphic adventure game. The first graphic adventure game was a 1980 game titled *Mystery House*, created by married couple Roberta and Ken Williams. It was designed, written, and illustrated by Roberta Williams, and programmed by Ken Williams (Nooney 2017). The game is a classic murder mystery story, as the title might suggest. The player, along with the rest of the cast of characters, is trapped inside a mansion with a murderer on the loose. The player must explore the mansion, discover clues, and uncover the identity of the murderer, or watch as each character falls victim to murder, before finally succumbing themselves. Of crucial importance are the inspirations for this game. Roberta Williams was specifically inspired by Agatha Christie's 1939 mystery novel *And Then There Were None*, and the 1949 murder mystery board game *Clue* (Nooney 2017).

From their very inception, graphic adventure games, including point-and-click adventure games, have had an inclination towards the enigmatic, featuring narratives that delve into the unknown and dangerous, exactly like *Fran Bow*. In fact, *Fran Bow* shares a remarkably similar origin, developed by married couple Natalia Figueroa and Isak Martinsson as an indie game. By way of pointing and clicking (or an input interface for *Mystery House*), the player in both games is free to investigate the game world with the aim of uncovering secrets at large. However, *Fran Bow* differs from games like *Mystery House* in its sources of inspiration. *Mystery House* follows in the footsteps of mystery novels, and expects the player to find conclusive answers to the mysteries at hand. *Fran Bow*, instead, follows in the footsteps of literary nonsense, where the act of investigating and progressing through the story usually creates more questions than answers.

Literary nonsense is considered a broad genre of literature which balances elements that make sense with those that do not, often by means of subverting either language conventions or

logical reasoning. Wim Tigges, in his book *An Anatomy of Literary Nonsense*, describes literary nonsense as a genre of narrative literature that balances a multiplicity of meaning with a simultaneous absence of meaning. It invites the reader to interpret the text while simultaneously avoiding the suggestion that there is a deeper meaning, as any connotations or associations the reader might make will lead to nothing (Tigges 1988).

To paint a clear picture, the game actually directly references a few popular examples and similarly whimsical stories. For example, late in the game, the player may find a picture of Fran alongside a supposed friend of hers, with Fran noting that “This is Alice from school” and that “she tells [Fran] stories about the wonderful land she visits sometimes.” This is clearly alluding to the children’s novel *Alice’s Adventures in Wonderland* by Lewis Carroll, which is considered one first examples, and arguably most popular, of literary nonsense. Much earlier in the game, Fran may also notice a pair of red shoes on top of a pile of random junk, exclaiming “I know a story about a girl with red shoes! And she had a dog.” This is clearly referencing Dorothy, the main character from *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* by L. Frank Baum. Notably, both of these stories feature a young girl travelling through a strange and whimsical world, and in the case of *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz*, alongside a pet companion, same as *Fran Bow*.

With a definition and some popular examples at hand, it is reasonable to think that *Fran Bow* takes inspiration from literary nonsense. More than that, however, *Fran Bow* actively employs the same techniques traditionally used in literary nonsense, but adapted into the medium of video games, much like *Mystery House* had to adapt the conventions of the murder mystery. Wim Tigges provides five broad devices by which most nonsense is achieved. Setting aside their descriptions for the moment, they are as follows: inversion, imprecision, infinite repetition, simultaneity, and arbitrariness (Tigges 1988). In literature, these devices often take the form of

wordplay such as puns, portmanteaus, neologisms, oxymorons, faulty metaphors, and more. This technique of manipulating language to create nonsense is largely only viable in writing, where the content of the medium is entirely prose with the occasional verse. It's not entirely clear at first glance how the genre of nonsense could make a jump to video games. Fortunately, these nonsense devices, as Wim Tigges describes them, are rather broad in scope and can be adopted by the medium of video games.

Despite the broad scope of these devices, adapting this genre into the medium of video games is not without its challenges. The very existence of video games as a visual medium presents a substantial hurdle. Wim Tigges writes that the reason this concept of balancing meaning with meaninglessness creates a feeling of nonsense is because it creates a dichotomy between reality and the imagery described by words on the page. A popular, yet simple, example is the poem *Jabberwocky* by Lewis Carroll, which uses phrases such as "vorpal sword" or "the frumious Bandersnatch," which sound as if they mean something, but upon closer inspection mean nothing. The greater the distance between what is presented and the expectations that are evoked, and the greater the tension created by these expectations, the more nonsensical the effect will be (Tigges 1988). This raises the question of how this tension can be created when presented with an image, as an image is its own descriptor. What one sees is what one gets, there is much less room for interpretability or expectation. Suddenly, the distance between reality and description is greatly diminished if not entirely removed. For any given scene, the player may not precisely know what they're looking at, but the imagery itself is clear and leaves no room for interpretation. Thus, an image alone is not enough to create nonsense, and must instead be taken in with the context it is in or the context it is missing.

This is what *Fran Bow* does. Instead of playing with language, *Fran Bow* focuses on manipulating logical reasoning and narrative structure, obfuscating narrative cohesion and verisimilitude, often with the assistance of gameplay and interactivity, and where images are concerned, the game often juxtaposes clear imagery with lack of context.

The most common technique that *Fran Bow* uses to accomplish this is called inversion, which is the deliberate subversion or dismissal of cause and effect or the natural order of things. The consistently cheery reactions from Fran towards various nightmarish scenes are a notable example. These are unexpected reactions to gruesome moments that are already both horrific and fantastical in their own right. In terms of gameplay, the most important mechanic of the game is an example of inversion. Fran has in her possession a bottle of a hallucinogenic drug labelled Duotine. Whenever Fran consumes this drug, she sees grotesque visions of blood, guts, and death everywhere. This, in and of itself, is an inversion, and a rather overt one at that, as it turns Fran's world into a dangerous and hostile one steeped in gore, with little rhyme or reason. This inversion is further accentuated by the realization that these visions are potentially real, with certain locations and items accessible only through these visions, and many of the creatures found therein having a real, sometimes even tangible, effect on the real world.

Additionally, many of the puzzles feature illogical or otherwise unexpected solutions, leaning heavily into the point-and-click adventure genre's tradition of using esoteric puzzles. For example, in Chapter 3, Fran scours the area for an admission ticket into a club. In the end, the solution is to have Fran hand draw the ticket herself, with the bouncer accepting it despite its apparent hand-drawn nature, reasoning that it is no less of a ticket for being made by Fran. At one point, Fran places a slab of wood with a doorknob glued onto it, leans it against the wall, and

proceeds to “open” the door, which now leads into the interior of a house. Much of the game is designed specifically to subvert real-world logic.

Another device used is called simultaneity, which is the joining of two or more seemingly disparate elements. This device is most often seen in-game when using and combining items. For example, in Chapter 3, Fran conducts a magic ritual that involves gathering 4 completely unrelated random items, including matches, a lemon, a fish, and a feather. In Chapter 4, Fran uses magical berries to repair an aircraft. In Chapter 2, Fran enlarges a toad using baking soda. While there is a traceable train of thought in the last one example, it is nonetheless still very whimsical. Many item interactions and combinations follow a similar childlike whimsical logic that subverts conventional wisdom.

While *Fran Bow* features many more examples of nonsense devices, these are some of the most notable. Through these examples, it is evident that *Fran Bow* is very deliberate and effective at generating nonsense through its gameplay. By framing the genre's propensity towards confusion as a supplement to *Fran Bow's* nonsense narrative, instead of a mechanical fault, even if the player is not directly aware of it, the once prominent common frustration of the genre is replaced by a feeling of cohesion between the player's action and the story.

As a nonsense story, *Fran Bow* is constantly balancing meaning with meaninglessness. Though much of the details of the story are obfuscated behind nonsense and up to individual interpretation, what is known for certainty is that Fran is unwell, and the nonsense invoked reflects how Fran feels and sees the world, with all the confusion and horror that comes with it, and invites the player to struggle through this strange world right alongside her.

The point-and-click adventure genre has seen a significant decline in popularity over the years, likely due in no small part to the genre's incongruous structure and its usage of absurd

puzzles. *Fran Bow*, in many ways, is not so different, partaking in the genre's tradition of featuring a cryptic narrative, while also sharing remarkably similar background to the earliest game in its prototype genre, as an indie game created by a married couple. However, *Fran Bow* leans into the often confusion-inducing gameplay of the genre and tells a deliberately illogical story, taking heavy inspiration from nonsense literature such as *Alice in Wonderland*, where other games have historically taken inspiration from murder mystery and detective novels. Though many of the details of the story are left ambiguous, whether Fran is experiencing a break from reality or truly witnessing supernatural events, *Fran Bow's* commitment to portraying the delicate state of mind of Fran is uniquely suited to its mix of game mechanics with its narrative style.

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